

FREE GUIDE

Start taking photographs

The essentials to leave auto mode and start making your own decisions. It works with any camera, including your phone.

MATÍAS SILVA · MATIASSILVAPH.COM

BEFORE YOU START

Technique can be learned. The eye is something you bring.

Some people have never owned a camera and see better than many photographers. If you are reading this, you probably already stop in front of things others walk past: a patch of light, a cat on a wall, a street that ends at the sea.

This guide will not give you that eye. You already have it. What it gives you are the tools so the camera stops getting in the way and starts following what you see.

It is meant to be read in an afternoon and practised over a month. Each chapter ends with a short exercise. Do them: ten minutes with the camera in your hands teach more than any manual.

What you will find

1. Light and exposure 3

2. Camera modes 5

3. The histogram 6

4. Focus 7

5. Composition 8

6. Reading the light 10

7. Setting up your camera on day one 11

8. A four-week practice plan 12

A NOTE

Button and menu names change from brand to brand. Where needed, the guide gives the name used by Sony, Canon, Nikon and Fujifilm. If your camera is not listed, the concept is the same: look it up in the manual with these words.

1

Light and exposure

A photograph is light reaching the sensor. Three settings control how much: aperture, shutter speed and ISO. All three add or remove light, but each one changes the image in a different way.

Aperture: what stays sharp

It is the size of the opening inside the lens, written with an f: f/2.8, f/5.6, f/11. **A low number means more light and a blurred background.** A high number means less light and everything sharp. Think of it as a fraction: f/2 is a bigger opening than f/16.

Shutter speed: what happens to movement

It is how long the shutter stays open. **1/1000 or faster freezes** a wave or a bird. 1/30 or slower blurs whatever moves, and a tripod helps. Handheld, do not go below 1 divided by the focal length: with a 50 mm lens, no slower than 1/50.

ISO: how much the signal is amplified

ISO 100 gives a clean image. ISO 3200 lets you shoot in low light, but grain appears. **Use it as a last resort**: as low as the situation allows.



Freezing the water takes a fast shutter speed. Praia do Norte, Nazaré.

Same light, different photo

Each setting moves in **stops**. One stop doubles or halves the light. That is why they can be traded: if you close the aperture by one stop, you get it back with one stop slower shutter speed or one stop more ISO.

APERTURE	SHUTTER	ISO	WHAT CHANGES
f/8	1/250	100	Starting point
f/5.6	1/500	100	Softer background, motion more frozen
f/11	1/250	200	More depth of field, a little more noise

All three combinations give the same exposure. What changes is how the photo looks, and that is the photographer's decision.

In what order to decide

1. **What do you want to show?** If the background matters, aperture leads. If movement matters, shutter speed leads.
2. **Set that one** and choose the other so the exposure works.
3. **ISO last**: raise it only when the other two leave no room.

Starting points

SITUATION	SUGGESTED SETTINGS
Street portrait	f/2.8–f/4 · 1/250 or faster · auto ISO
Landscape or street by day	f/8–f/11 · ISO 100
Waves, surf or sport	1/1000–1/2000 · wide aperture
Sunset	f/8 · ISO 100 · meter on the sky
City at night	Tripod · f/8 · ISO 100 · several seconds

EXERCISE

Pick a subject close by and a background far away. Take the same photo at f/4, f/8 and f/16 and compare how much the background blurs.

2
Camera modes

The mode dial says something simple: who decides each setting, you or the camera.

MODE	SONY / NIKON	CANON	YOU CHOOSE	WHEN
Aperture priority	A	Av	Aperture	Portrait, street, landscape, travel
Shutter priority	S	Tv	Shutter speed	Surf, sport, animals
Manual	M	M	Both	Night, studio, steady light
Program	P	P	ISO and compensation	Quick shots

Many Fujifilm cameras have no mode dial: you choose with the shutter speed dial and the aperture ring, and the letter A means the camera works out that value.

Where to start

For the first few weeks, use A or Av. You decide how much the background blurs and watch which shutter speed the camera picks. If it drops below 1/60 in low light, open the aperture or raise the ISO.

A trick for movement

Manual with auto ISO: you set the shutter speed and aperture, which define the image, and the ISO follows the changes in light.

Exposure compensation (+/−)

The camera sometimes gets it wrong. It darkens very bright scenes such as a beach or white water: correct with +0.7 or +1. It brightens dark scenes and sunsets too much: correct with −0.7 or −1. **Then go back to 0.**

EXERCISE

Find something that moves: a fountain, cars, people. In S or Tv, shoot the same scene at 1/1000, 1/125 and 1/15 and compare.

3

The histogram

The screen lies: in sunlight it looks dark, at night it looks bright. The histogram does not depend on that. It is the most reliable way to know whether the exposure is right.

It is a graph of how many pixels there are at each brightness level. Black is on the left, white on the right, and the mid-tones in between.

What it warns you about

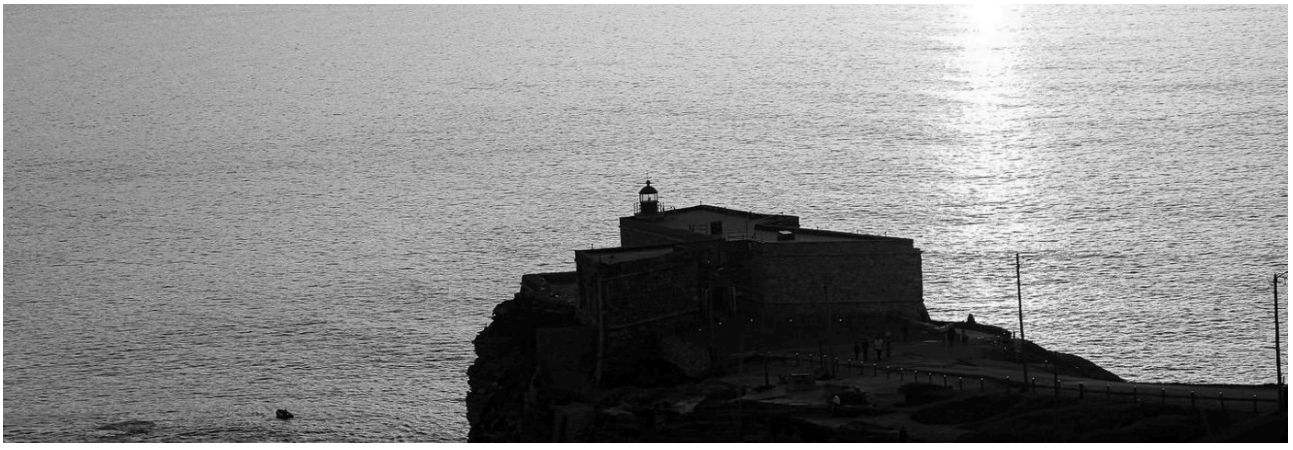
- **A mountain cut off at the right edge**: blown highlights. That area is pure white with no information, and it cannot be recovered.
- **A mountain cut off at the left edge**: crushed shadows. They can be recovered a little, but noise appears.

There is no correct histogram

A sunny beach has its mountain on the right, and that is fine. A street at night has it on the left, and that is fine too. The question is not whether it is centred but **whether something important was clipped**. If the only thing touching the edge is the sun, it does not matter. If it is a face or the crest of a wave, correct it.

Two tips

- Use the **RGB histogram** if your camera has one: at sunset, the red channel clips before the rest.
- Turn on the **highlight warning** in the playback menu: blown areas blink.



In backlight, the only thing allowed to touch the right edge is the sun. Forte de São Miguel Arcanjo, Nazaré.

4
Focus

A badly exposed photo can still be powerful. A photo focused in the wrong place almost never is.

Single or continuous focus

MODE	SONY / NIKON / FUJIFILM	CANON	FOR
Single	AF-S	One Shot	Still subjects: portrait, landscape, architecture
Continuous	AF-C	AI Servo / Servo	Moving subjects: surf, sport, children, animals

Choose the focus point yourself

In auto, the camera decides what to focus on and usually picks whatever is closest or has the most contrast. Choose **a single point** or a small zone and move it to what matters. In portraits, the eye closest to the camera. Many mirrorless cameras detect eyes on their own: turn it on.

Back-button focus

Many photographers separate focus from the shutter: a rear button focuses and the shutter button only fires. You focus once, recompose and shoot as many times as you like without the camera refocusing. It is set in the custom functions; look for "AF-ON", "AEL/AF" or "back-button focus".

Depth of field

With very wide apertures (f/1.8, f/2.8) the sharp zone is extremely thin: if you focus on the nose, the eyes may come out soft. For portraits, **f/2.8 to f/4** is a good balance.

> EXERCISE
>
> Put three objects in a row at different distances. At f/2.8, focus on each one separately and see how the photo changes. Then repeat at f/11.

5
Composition

Composing is deciding what goes in the frame and where. Rules help you start; with time, you break them on purpose.

Rule of thirds

Divide the frame into three parts across and down. Place the horizon on one of the lines, not in the middle, and the subject on one of the intersections. Turn on the camera's grid.

Leading lines

Streets, railings, the edge of the sea. They lead the eye to the subject or into the depth of the image.

A frame within the frame

An arch, a window, some branches. They organise the image and add depth.

Layers

Something near, something in the middle and something far. A flower in the foreground, the town and the sea behind.

Simplify

Before you shoot, check the edges. A bin, a cable or half a car stand out more in the photo than in real life. Often, one step to the side is enough.

Leave space

If the subject looks or moves towards one side, leave room on that side.



The branches frame the town and the trunk adds depth: a frame within the frame and layers in one photo. Nazaré.

A clear subject

If you cannot say in one sentence what the photo shows, it is not a photo yet.

The difference between a record of a place and a photograph is usually that: having a subject. A cat on a wall, a family walking towards the sea, a sign pointing where everyone is going.

Before you shoot, ask yourself: **what made me stop here?** Whatever stopped you is the subject. Everything else in the frame has to support it or go.



The diagonal of the wall, the warm surface and the cold sky. One subject, and the whole frame works for it. Nazaré.

EXERCISE

Go for a walk with a single theme: what holds out in the middle of the city. A tree among the concrete, an old house between new buildings. Come back with five photos, not fifty.

6
Reading the light

The same street changes completely with the time of day. Learning to see light is what improves your photos fastest.

TIME	WHAT THE LIGHT IS LIKE	WHAT IT IS GOOD FOR
Golden hour (the hour before sunset and after sunrise)	Low, warm, long shadows	Portraits, street, landscape. Almost everything.
Blue hour (just after sunset)	Soft, cool, deep blue sky	Cities with the lights on
Midday sun	Hard, from above, short sharp shadows	Graphic shadows, architecture. Difficult for portraits.
Overcast	Diffuse, even, no shadows	Soft portraits, details, colours

Where it comes from

- **Front light**: shows everything, but flattens.
- **Side light**: gives volume and texture. The favourite for portraits and architecture.
- **Backlight**: silhouettes, rim light, atmosphere. Meter on the sky and let the rest go dark.

A habit

Before you raise the camera, look at where the shadows are. If you do not like the light, sometimes the answer is to wait half an hour or come back another day.

> EXERCISE
>
> Photograph the same place near your home at three different times: morning, midday and golden hour. Compare the three.

7

Setting up your camera on day one

Ten minutes of setup will save you a lot of lost photos.

- [ ] **Quality: RAW + JPEG.** The RAW is your original for editing and your proof of authorship; the JPEG is for quick sharing.
- [ ] **Correct date and time**, with your time zone. They are written into every file.
- [ ] **Author and copyright** in the metadata, if your camera allows it (on some it is loaded with the manufacturer's software).
- [ ] **Colour space: sRGB**, used by the web and most competitions.
- [ ] **Image review: 2 seconds**, with the histogram visible.
- [ ] **Highlight warning** turned on.
- [ ] **Grid** on the screen and in the viewfinder.
- [ ] **Focus beep off**, for the street.
- [ ] **Auto ISO with a maximum** (for example, 3200 or 6400 depending on your camera).
- [ ] **A or Av mode** to start, and single-point focus.
- [ ] **Card formatted in the camera**, after copying the photos to your computer.

THE MOST IMPORTANT HABIT

After every outing, copy the photos to your computer and to a cloud, in folders by date and place (for example, 2026-11-08_San-Miguel). The originals are your archive and, for many competitions, your proof that the photo is yours.

8

A four-week practice plan

One outing a week is enough. What matters is going out with a brief.

Week 1 · Aperture

A or Av mode. Ten scenes, each at f/4 and f/11. Learn to see how the background changes.

Week 2 · Movement

S or Tv mode. Water, people, cars, at 1/1000, 1/125 and 1/15. Check the histogram after each photo.

Week 3 · Light

Go out only at golden hour or blue hour. Try backlight and side light. Use exposure compensation.

Week 4 · A series

Choose a theme and come back with five photos that read together. What holds out, lit windows, people waiting. The same edit on all of them.

AND THEN

Go through the photos from the four weeks and pick the three best. Ask yourself why they are better than the rest. That answer is your style starting to show.

Photography begins with not getting used to things.

Technique is learned through practice, and this guide is a starting point. You already have the eye. What brings the two together is learning to stop: walking more slowly, pausing in front of what calls you, and giving the photo time to appear.

Thank you for reading.

Keep learning

The blog has full articles on every topic in this guide, with more examples and exercises:
matiassilvaph.com/en/blog

Photographs and process on Instagram: **@matiassilva.ph**
Enquiries: **matiassilva.ph@gmail.com**

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